

Rental Application Fast-Track Checklist — ACT

Win the lease, even with no rental history or connections.

Correct as at July 2026. General information only, not legal advice.

Section 1 — Know Your Rights Before You Apply

- ☐ [] **Know your tenancy is governed by the Residential Tenancies Act 1997 (ACT)**, with the ACT Civil and Administrative Tribunal (ACAT) handling disputes.
- ☐ [] **Know your rent increase protections apply from the very start of your tenancy** — increases can't occur within the first 12 months, so a fresh lease gives you at least a year of price certainty.

Section 2 — Documents to Have Ready

- ☐ [] **Photo ID** (driver's licence or passport).
- ☐ [] **Proof of income** — payslips, employment letter, or for students/first-time renters: Centrelink statements, scholarship confirmation, or guarantor documents.
- ☐ [] **Rental history/references** — previous landlord/agent details, or alternative references if you're a first-time renter.
- ☐ [] **Bank statements**, if requested.

Section 3 — The Application Itself

- ☐ [] **Apply promptly after inspecting** — Canberra's rental market remains competitive for well-located properties.
- ☐ [] **Attend the inspection in person if possible.**
- ☐ [] **Follow up politely, once**, if you haven't heard back within a few days.

Section 4 — For Students & First-Time Renters Specifically

- ☐ [] **Consider a guarantor** if you lack independent rental/income history — Canberra's significant student and public-service-transfer population means agencies are often reasonably familiar with these situations, but confirm the specific agency accepts it.
- ☐ [] **Highlight stability signals** — enrolment confirmation, course length, stable casual or public sector work history.
- ☐ [] **Consider co-applying with reliable housemates** for a stronger combined application.
- ☐ [] **Don't be discouraged by rejections** — apply for multiple properties in parallel.

Section 5 — Know Your Ongoing Protections Once You're In

- ☐ [] **Know your bond is capped at 4 weeks' rent**, and must be lodged with the ACT Revenue Office.
- ☐ [] **Know rent increase rules**: at least **8 weeks' written notice**, and no increase within the first 12 months of your tenancy.
- ☐ [] **Know disputes go to ACAT**, not a general court — a specialist tribunal for tenancy matters.

Quick Reference — Key ACT Rental Application Facts

ITEM	DETAIL
Governing legislation	Residential Tenancies Act 1997 (ACT)
Maximum bond	4 weeks' rent
Rent increase notice	8 weeks, none within first 12 months
Dispute resolution	ACAT (ACT Civil and Administrative Tribunal)

© HouseHQ. General information only, current as at the date shown — not legal advice. For disputes or questions about your specific application, contact ACT Revenue Office or Access Canberra.